



Occupational hazard: Shreyas Iyer's injury is a reminder that not every setback can be managed away, with some simply part of the physical risks of elite cricket. GETTY IMAGES

capacities," Leipus says.

But critics argue that the Bronco Test hardly checks for the kind of fitness needed in cricket and leaves players prone to injuries.

"The 2k time trial and the Bronco Test do not measure how fit the bowler or player is. It measures the general conditional fitness. It is a test taken from other sports (rugby). The stride pattern, the ground contact time and the speed (metres per second) for these tests are a lot lower, about four metres per second. They train for this level when, in cricket, they are required to only run at seven metres per second. The S&C, rightfully or wrongfully, is

judged on whether the cricketers are clearing these tests. So it is misguided. That is why I feel there is a spike in injuries. Bowlers need to bowl and train with specificity. They need to bowl intensely and often. Skill requires frequency of practice," the bowling coach says.

But this is just one branch of thinking. That the application of sports science to elevate player performance has permeated through global cricket itself hints at its feasibility.

Shanker Basu, former India S&C head, who held his post through one of India's golden eras in Test cricket, opines that only a proper scientific approach can allow a player to survive all three formats.

"Today's cricketers are extremely professional. If you give them a roadmap, they follow it to the T. I don't think that is the case; maybe some people want to believe [that

S&C is not ideal in cricket], but by and large the professionalism in cricket has only improved. We have professionals now who are guiding the cricketers.

"To play all three formats takes a toll on the player; you need a different kind of preparation. You need to account for so many factors that if you do not adhere to the plans, and are not scientific enough, you will get the raw end of the deal. It all depends on what you want out of the athlete."

Time heals everything

But beyond workload and conditioning a player for the rigours of international cricket, the prevention of injuries depends on the most obvious factor: fixing the injury properly!

Leipus broadens it out into two aspects: fit to play and fit to perform. "You can get somebody fit to play; that could be you or me."